MSC MARRIAGE AND FAMILY THERAPY

LECTURE LIBRARY  VOLUME 6 OF 28

# MFT 706

# Clinical Practice and Techniques

16 teaching weeks  10 practicals  4 worked cases  1 figure

SEMESTER ONE

1.71 units  Prerequisite: MFT 701, 702

> This is the skills course.

One of 28 self-contained course books in the MSc Marriage and Family Therapy lecture library: a full taught semester per volume, with cases, practicals, assessment briefs, glossaries and model answers.


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2026 edition

# MFT 706  Clinical Practice and Techniques

**MSc Marriage and Family Therapy**  Semester One  1.71 Units  16 teaching weeks  Prerequisite: MFT 701, 702

This volume is one of 28 course books that together cover the whole MSc Marriage and Family Therapy taught programme. Each book is written to carry a 14 16 week semester on its own: every week pairs a core idea with the practice that follows from it, a worked case, and a reflective task, and each book closes with an integration chapter, a glossary and a self-assessment paper with model answers.

The books are designed to be read straight through before the semester begins, revisited week by week, and used again in revision. Cross-references point to the other volumes where a topic is treated in more depth.


### How to cite this volume

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### A note on the case material

All families, couples and individuals in this book are fictional composites. They are written to teach pattern recognition, not to describe any real person. Nothing here replaces supervised clinical practice, professional registration, legal advice or medical care; legal content is orientation only and must be checked against the law of the relevant jurisdiction.

# The lecture library

Twenty-eight self-contained course books carry the taught programme: eight in Semester One, seven in Semester Two, seven in Semester Three including the thesis, and six electives. The volume you are holding is marked in the margin.

| Code | Course | Semester | Units |
|---|---|---|---|
| MFT 701 | Fundamentals of Marriage and Family Therapy | One | 1.71 |
| MFT 702 | Theories of Family Therapy | One | 1.71 |
| MFT 703 | Human Development Across the Lifespan | One | 1.71 |
| MFT 704 | Ethical and Legal Issues in Therapy | One | 1.71 |
| MFT 705 | Research Methods in Marriage and Family Therapy | One | 1.71 |
| **MFT 706** | **Clinical Practice and Techniques** | One | 1.71 |
| MFT 707 | Assessment and Diagnosis in Family Therapy | One | 1.71 |
| MFT 708 | Cultural Competence in Therapy | One | 1.71 |
| MFT 709 | Group Therapy Techniques | Two | 1.71 |
| MFT 710 | Couples Therapy | Two | 1.71 |
| MFT 711 | Child and Adolescent Therapy | Two | 1.71 |
| MFT 712 | Crisis Intervention Strategies | Two | 1.71 |
| MFT 713 | Substance Abuse and Family Dynamics | Two | 1.71 |
| MFT 714 | Trauma-Informed Care | Two | 1.71 |
| MFT 715 | Family Systems Theory | Two | 1.71 |
| MFT 716 | Communication Skills in Therapy | Three | 1.71 |
| MFT 717 | Psychopathology in Families | Three | 1.71 |
| MFT 718 | Intimacy and Relationship Dynamics | Three | 1.71 |
| MFT 719 | Family Life Cycle and Transitions | Three | 1.71 |
| MFT 720 | Supervision and Consultation in Therapy | Three | 1.71 |
| MFT 721 | Research Methodology | Three | 1.71 |
| MFT 722 | Professional Development and Self-Care | Electives | 1.71 |
| MFT 723 | Special Populations in Therapy | Electives | 1.71 |
| MFT 724 | Family Law and Advocacy | Electives | 1.71 |
| MFT 725 | Integrative Approaches in Therapy | Electives | 1.71 |
| MFT 726 | Neurobiology of Relationships | Electives | 1.71 |
| MFT 727 | Play Therapy Techniques | Electives | 1.71 |
| MFT 770 | Master Thesis | Three | 1.71 |

# Contents


How to use this book . . . 5

1. Course description . . . 5

2. Learning outcomes . . . 5

3. Assessment . . . 5

4. The sixteen-week plan . . . 6

Week 1 The architecture of a session . . . 6

Week 2 Joining . . . 7

Week 3 Listening . . . 7

Week 4 Questioning I . . . 8

Week 5 Questioning II . . . 9

Week 6 Enactment . . . 10

Week 7 Reframing, normalising, positive connotation . . . 10

Week 8 Observed session 1 . . . 11

Week 9 Working with conflict and escalation . . . 11

Week 10 Silence, tears, and the therapist's discomfort . . . 12

Week 11 Structuring the room and the system . . . 12

Week 12 Between-session tasks . . . 13

Week 13 Impasses, non-attendance and drop-out . . . 14

Week 14 Working with children and adolescents in family sessions . . . 14

Week 15 Endings . . . 14

Week 16 Observed session 2 . . . 15

Glossary . . . 16

Self-assessment . . . 16

- Multiple choice . . . 16
- Answer key . . . 16
- Short answer . . . 17
- Essay (choose one, 1,800 words) . . . 17

Further reading . . . 17

**Course leader's summary.** This is the skills course. You will leave able to structure a session, ask six kinds of question deliberately, conduct an enactment, reframe without dismissing, assign a task that gets done, and end therapy well. Most of the hours are practice, not lecture.

## How to use this book

Technique is a set of **deliberate choices**, not a personality. Each week introduces one family of skills, gives you the language, shows a transcript, and then requires you to perform it. Read the transcript aloud before the lab: your mouth needs to know the sentences before your mind can choose them under pressure.

## 1. Course description

The gap between knowing about family therapy and doing it is bridged by rehearsal. This course covers the micro-skills (joining, questioning, reflecting, summarising), the meso-skills (structuring a session, managing conflict, conducting an enactment), and the macro-skills (planning treatment, assigning tasks, handling impasse, terminating).

It is assessed almost entirely on **performance**, because a student who can describe an enactment and cannot conduct one is not yet a clinician.

## 2. Learning outcomes

| # | Outcome | Assessed |
|---|---|---|
| LO1 | Structure a session with a clear opening, middle and close | Observed session |
| LO2 | Use six categories of question deliberately and appropriately | Observed session, exam |
| LO3 | Conduct an enactment and manage its escalation | Observed session |
| LO4 | Reframe, normalise and positively connote without dismissing distress | Skills test |
| LO5 | Design and review between-session tasks | Task portfolio |
| LO6 | Manage conflict, silence and resistance in the room | Observed session |
| LO7 | Plan and conduct a planned ending | Viva, log |

## 3. Assessment

| Component | Weight | Due |
|---|---|---|
| Skills triad log (weekly) | 20% | Fortnightly |
| Observed session 1 (20 min, mid-semester) | 20% | Week 8 |
| Task portfolio (5 designed tasks with rationale) | 20% | Week 12 |

| Component | Weight | Due |
|---|---|---|
| Observed session 2 (40 min, with feedback) | 40% | Week 16 |

## 4. The sixteen-week plan

| Week | Skill family | Practical |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | The architecture of a session | Structure a 50-minute session |
| 2 | Joining and the first five minutes | Opening rounds, three styles |
| 3 | Listening: paraphrase, reflect, summarise | Reflection-only interview |
| 4 | Questioning I: linear, circular, strategic | Circular questioning drill |
| 5 | Questioning II: reflexive, future-oriented, scaling | Solution-focused drill |
| 6 | Enactment: making the family talk to each other | Enactment lab |
| 7 | Reframing, normalising, positive connotation | Reframe tennis |
| 8 | **Observed session 1** | Assessment and feedback |
| 9 | Working with conflict and escalation | De-escalation drill |
| 10 | Silence, tears, and the therapist's discomfort | Tolerance-of-silence lab |
| 11 | Structuring: who sits where, who speaks when, subgroups | Subgroup session design |
| 12 | Between-session tasks and homework | Task portfolio workshop |
| 13 | Impasses, non-attendance, and drop-out | Difficult-session rehearsal |
| 14 | Working with children and adolescents in family sessions | Live supervision |
| 15 | Endings: planned, unplanned, and therapeutic | Termination role-play |
| 16 | **Observed session 2** | Full assessment |

## Week 1 The architecture of a session

A 50-minute family session has five movements. Beginners skip the first and the last, which is why their sessions feel formless.

| Movement | Minutes | Purpose |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Opening / re-joining | 3 5 | Reconnect, state the frame, ask what has changed |
| 2. Agenda | 2 3 | Whose concern is most urgent this week? |
| 3. Work | 25 30 | The core intervention: enactment, questioning, restructuring |
| 4. Consolidation | 5 7 | Summarise, check, agree the task |
| 5. Close | 3 5 | Confirm next appointment, name one thing to watch |

**The "what has changed?" opener.** Never start where you left off. Start with the family's own observation: "Before we begin what has been different this week, even slightly?" This trains the family to notice change and gives you data about what is already working.

> **PRACTICAL**
> Write the five movements on a card. Use it in every triad this semester. By Week 8 you should not need it.

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## Week 2 Joining

**Three joining styles** (choose deliberately):

1. **Tracking** follow the family's language and pace. "Tell me about 'stubborn' what does it look like in your house?"
2. **Accommodation** adopt the family's structure for the moment. With a hierarchical family, address the father first; with a chaotic family, bring structure immediately.
3. **Personal joining** offer a small, true piece of yourself. "I grew up in a house where nobody raised their voice either. It took me years to learn to argue."

**What joining is not.** It is not agreement, flattery, or becoming the family's friend. You can join and disagree: "I like the way you two can laugh at this. I am going to say something you may not like."

**Three failures of joining.**

| Failure | Symptom | Repair |
|---|---|---|
| Over-joining | You are now part of the family's pattern | Name it: "I think I just took your side. Let me step back." |
| Under-joining | Family answers in monosyllables | Slow down; ask about something concrete and safe |
| Premature confrontation | Family defensive from minute five | Return to their account for ten minutes before challenging |

> **PRACTICAL**
> Three rounds of five-minute openings, each with a different joining style. The "family" rates: did I feel understood? Did I feel patronised? Did I want to continue?

---

## Week 3 Listening

**Paraphrase** return the content. **Reflect** return the feeling. **Summarise** return the pattern across people and time.

Client: "He comes home, eats, and goes to the room. I sit in the parlour with the children and I feel like a widow."

- Paraphrase: "So most evenings he is in the room and you are with the children."
- Reflect: "You feel alone in your own marriage."
- Summarise (later, across people): "So there are two versions of the evening: yours is that he leaves; his is that he arrives already exhausted and afraid of saying the wrong thing. Both of you are alone in the same house."

**The 2:1 rule for beginners.** Two reflections for every question. It slows the interview, produces richer material, and prevents the interrogation pattern families experience in first sessions.

> **PRACTICAL**
> Ten-minute interview in which you may not ask a single question. Only paraphrase, reflect and summarise. Note how uncomfortable it is, and what the client does when you stop asking.

---

## Week 4 Questioning I

Six categories, each with a purpose. Learn the label so you can choose under pressure.

| Type | Purpose | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **Linear** | Gather facts | "When did the arguing start?" |
| **Circular** | Reveal difference and relationship | "Who notices first when your mother goes quiet?" |
| **Strategic** | Introduce a direction | "What would happen if you stopped reminding him?" |
| **Reflexive** | Invite a new perspective | "If your daughter could hear this conversation, what would she say you both believe?" |
| **Future-oriented** | Open possibility | "Suppose this is better in six months what would be different?" |
| **Scaling** | Make change measurable | "On 0 10, how close are you as a couple? What would one point look like?" |

**The circular question is the field's signature skill.** Build it from three elements: a difference (who/what/how much), a relationship (between whom), and a comparison (more than, less than, compared with).

- Weak: "Is your husband supportive?"
- Better: "Who in the family would say your husband is most supportive and who would disagree?"
- Best: "If your mother were watching the two of you last night, what would she say was different between how he spoke to you and how he speaks to your sister?"

> **PRACTICAL**
> Circular questioning drill: 10 minutes, all questions must be circular. Observer counts and classifies. Target: 80% genuinely circular.

## Week 5 Questioning II

**Reflexive questions** invite the family to observe itself. They are the safest way to raise something difficult, because the family supplies the content:

- "What do you think your son has learned about marriage from watching the two of you?"
- "If I asked your daughter who is in charge in this house, what would she say?"
- "What is the most useful thing that could happen in this session and the most uncomfortable?"

**Future questions** create hope without denying the present:

- "Suppose we meet in a year and this is behind you. What would you want to be able to say you did?"
- "What would your father have wanted for this family?"

**The question to avoid:** "Why?" in relation to behaviour. "Why did you shout at her?" invites defence or invention. "What happened just before you shouted?" invites sequence.




Figure 5.1 Solution-focused moves: strengths, miracle, scaling, exceptions, task

> **PRACTICAL**
> Convert ten "why" questions into "what/how/who" questions. Compare the answers you get in role-play.

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## Week 6 Enactment

**Definition.** Enactment is the deliberate direction of family members to speak **to each other** in the session, while the therapist moves to the edge of the action.

**Why it matters.** Most families come to therapy to talk about each other to a third party. Enactment converts description into live interaction, where you can observe and shape it. It is the single most powerful structural technique.

**The four-step protocol.**

1. **Block the detour:** "Don't tell me tell her."
2. **Specify the content:** "Tell her what you needed on Saturday, in one sentence."
3. **Direct the process:** "Look at him, not at me." "Say it again, slower."
4. **Intensify or interrupt:** "You just smiled. Say it again with the smile." Or: "Stop. What just happened?"

**Transcript (structural enactment with a couple).**

> **THERAPIST:**
> You have both told me about Saturday. Now I want you to tell each other. Funmi, tell Femi what you needed on Saturday one sentence, and look at him. **Funmi:** (to therapist) I needed him to **Therapist:** To him. **Funmi:** I needed you to call and say you would be late. **Femi:** I did call **Therapist:** Femi, answer her, not me. **Femi:** (pause) I did call. At four. You didn't pick up. **Funmi:** I was with your mother. **Therapist:** Stop there. Funmi what happened inside you when he said that?

**Hazards.** Enactment can escalate. Have a stop signal, keep your voice calm and slow, and interrupt before contempt. With coercive control, do not enact conflict; safety first (MFT 704).

> **PRACTICAL**
> Enactment lab. Triads with a scripted couple. The therapist may only use the four steps. Observer records: did the therapist stay out of the content? Did the family speak to each other for more than 90 seconds?

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## Week 7 Reframing, normalising, positive connotation

**Reframing** changes the frame, not the facts. It is the most-used intervention in the field and the most easily abused.

| Original frame | Reframe | Risk |
|---|---|---|
| "He is controlling" | "He is frightened of losing you and tries to hold on" | Can excuse control |
| "She is manipulative" | "She has learned that tears are the only way to be heard" | Can remove accountability |
| "You are lazy" | "You are exhausted and have stopped asking for help" | Can be heard as excusing |
| "Our son is defiant" | "Your son is trying to protect his mother" | Can burden the child further |

**Three tests before you reframe.**

1. **Is it true enough?** A reframe that the family rejects as false damages alliance.
2. **Does it open or close action?** "He is frightened" opens action; "he is a monster" closes it.
3. **Does it remove accountability?** Reframes should increase the family's sense of agency, not reduce it.

**Normalising** placing behaviour in a developmental or statistical context: "Arguing about money is the most common argument in the first five years of marriage. It is not a sign that you are failing."

**Positive connotation** (Milan) describing all behaviour as serving the family system: "Your arguments may be the family's way of ensuring that nothing important is decided without both of you being fully present." Use sparingly; it can sound like sarcasm.

> **PRACTICAL**
> "Reframe tennis": one student states a complaint, the partner must return three successive reframes, and the first student says which one she would accept and why.

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## Week 8 Observed session 1

Twenty minutes with a role-played family. Assessed against five criteria: structure (does the session have a shape?), joining (does each person feel heard?), questioning (at least three circular), one enactment, and a summary with a task.

Feedback is given live by the observing group using the structured sheet, then by the lecturer.

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## Week 9 Working with conflict and escalation

**The therapist's job during conflict is regulation, not resolution.** Five moves:

1. **Slow the pace.** "Stop. Say that again, more slowly."
2. **Name the process.** "I notice that every time she raises her voice, you leave the room. Can we stay with it for two minutes?"

3. **Structural interruption.** "I am going to ask you both to be quiet for one minute and let me speak to your son."
4. **Separate content from process.** "The topic is money. The pattern is that you both start explaining before the other finishes."
5. **Time-out with a return.** "Let's take two minutes. We are not finished."

**Escalation signs to interrupt early:** raised volume, contempt (eye-rolling, mockery), one person standing, threats, children becoming still or leaving, your own heart rate rising.

> **DE-ESCALATION DRILL**
> Pairs escalate a scripted argument on cue. The therapist must interrupt before the third escalation. Repeat until the interruption happens at the right moment, not the safe one.

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## Week 10 Silence, tears, and the therapist's discomfort

**Silence is a technique.** There are four kinds:

| Silence | Meaning | Response |
|---|---|---|
| Processing | Someone is thinking | Wait. Count to fifteen. |
| Emotional | Feeling has arrived | Stay; soften your face; do not rescue |
| Resistance | Something is not being said | Name it gently: "Something just shifted. What happened?" |
| Your own | You are lost | Say so: "Let me think for a moment about what I am hearing." |

**Tears.** Do not hand a tissue immediately; it tells the person to stop. Wait three seconds, then offer. Ask: "Is this a sadness that has been waiting a long time?"

**Your discomfort is data.** If you want to fill the silence, ask what you are avoiding. If you feel irritated with one family member, ask what they represent to you. This is the beginning of using the self as an instrument (developed in MFT 720 and 722).

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## Week 11 Structuring the room and the system

**Physical structure.** Seat families so that coalition patterns are visible and can be interrupted. Put the parents together and the children together; sit between people who never speak; never sit in a line that recreates the hierarchy you are trying to change.

**Who attends.** Deliberately choose the combination: whole family, parents only, siblings, one parent and one child, individual. State the rationale: "Next week I would like to see the two of you alone, so you can talk as a couple without the children carrying it."

**Subgroup sessions.** A powerful and under-used technique: see the parents alone to plan a united message, then bring the children in and have the parents deliver it together. The intervention is the difference between the two sessions.

**PRACTICAL**

Design a three-session sequence using different attendance combinations for the Adeyemi family (MFT 701). Justify each combination.

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## Week 12 Between-session tasks

**A task is a test of the system, not homework.** It should be small, specific, behavioural, and designed to produce information.

**The four-part task formula.**

1. **What exactly** ("For the next seven days, at dinner ")
2. **Who does what** (" each of you names one thing that went well in your day ")
3. **What to notice** (" and notice what happens to the atmosphere by Thursday.")
4. **What to bring back** (" we will look at what you noticed next week.")

**Five useful task types.**

| Type | Purpose | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Observation | Gather data | "Notice and write down every time the argument stops before it starts." |
| Ritual | Interrupt a sequence | "One night this week, the parents go out for one hour. The children are told in advance." |
| Behavioural exchange | Build positives | "Three small caring acts each per day, unannounced." |
| Communication | Practise a skill | "Two 15-minute speaker listener conversations, timer on." |
| Paradoxical (rare, supervised) | Change the symptom's function | "On Tuesday, have the argument on purpose for ten minutes at 8 p.m." |

**Why tasks fail.** Too big, too vague, agreed under pressure in the last two minutes of the session, or the family does not believe the therapist believes they will do it. Write the task down and give them the paper.

**TASK PORTFOLIO (20%)**

Five tasks, each with: the presenting problem, the task, the rationale, the predicted failure mode, and the review question you would ask.

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## Week 13 Impasses, non-attendance and drop-out

**When a session goes flat.** Three likely causes: the family is protecting a secret; the therapist has joined too closely to one side; or the work has reached material the family did not consent to. Name the process: "I notice we have been very polite for twenty minutes. What are we all avoiding?"

**When someone does not attend.** Never pretend it did not happen. "Your father chose not to come today. Let's think about what that means." Explore whether attendance is a form of communication.

**When the family drops out.** Follow up once, by phone, briefly and without pressure; record the reason if given; and use it as clinical data. In family therapy, drop-out is the most common negative outcome, and it is usually visible early the first two sessions predict the rest.

**Impasses with the therapist.** If you are bored, angry, or over-involved, that is information about the system. Take it to supervision before you act on it.

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## Week 14 Working with children and adolescents in family sessions

**Practical adjustments.**

- Shorter sessions for younger children (30 40 minutes), or split sessions.
- Explain the frame to the child directly, not only to the parents: "In this room we talk, and sometimes we draw."
- Give the child a legitimate role: "You are the expert on what happens at school."
- Protect the child from being made the messenger: "That is a question for your mother to answer, not you."
- Never ask a child to choose sides in front of the parents.

**The adolescent rule.** Speak to the adolescent as the primary person for at least five minutes. Ask their version first. Parents' accounts of adolescents are systematically more negative than adolescents' own reports and than teachers' reports.

> **LIVE SUPERVISION**
> One student conducts a family session with a trained role-play family while the group observes; the supervisor may call in with one suggestion. Debrief with the family's experience.

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## Week 15 Endings

**Planned ending.** Agree it in advance; review what changed and what did not; name the risk of relapse; write a one-page relapse plan with the family; leave the door open.

**The four questions of a good ending.**

1. What is different now, in your own words?
2. What did each of you do that made the difference?
3. What is most likely to make it come back?
4. What will you do when you notice the first sign?

**Unplanned endings.** Client-initiated endings are common; acknowledge and, where possible, send one closing message. Therapist-initiated endings (illness, placement change, moving) require a proper handover session an abrupt ending can replicate an abandonment for the family.

**Do not adopt.** A warm ending can slip into a friendship. Say what the relationship was: "I have enjoyed working with you. This has been a professional relationship, and it ends here that is what makes it safe."

> **PRACTICAL**
> Termination role-play: a family that has improved and is anxious about stopping. The therapist must review, name the risk, write the plan and close, in 15 minutes.

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## Week 16 Observed session 2

Forty minutes, full assessment, using the criteria below and a self-assessment submitted in advance.

| Criterion | Weight |
|---|---|
| Structure and pacing | 20% |
| Joining and alliance with each member | 20% |
| Questioning (range and timing) | 20% |
| One deliberate intervention well executed | 25% |
| Summary, task and closing | 15% |

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## Glossary

**Accommodation** adapting one's style to a family's organisation in order to join it. **Circular question** a question about difference or relationship that reveals pattern. **Enactment** directing family members to interact with each other in session. **Intensity** raising the emotional or interactional stakes to produce change. **Positive connotation** framing all behaviour as serving the family system. **Reflexive question** a question inviting the family to observe itself. **Reframe** relabelling behaviour within a new, usually relational, frame. **Subgroup session** seeing part of the family deliberately, then using the difference. **Unbalancing** deliberately supporting one member to shift the system's equilibrium.

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## Self-assessment

### Multiple choice

**1.** The correct response to "she is manipulative" as a first formulation is: (a) agree (b) challenge the parent (c) gather specific behavioural sequences (d) diagnose

**2.** "Who notices first when your mother goes quiet?" is: (a) linear (b) circular (c) strategic (d) closed

**3.** The main purpose of enactment is to: (a) gather history (b) observe and shape live interaction (c) calm the family (d) demonstrate expertise

**4.** A reframe should: (a) excuse the behaviour (b) open new action without removing accountability (c) always be positive (d) replace diagnosis

**5.** Two reflections for every question is recommended because it: (a) fills time (b) reduces interrogation and enriches material (c) prevents emotion (d) shortens sessions

**6.** A task is most likely to fail when it is: (a) written down (b) small and specific (c) agreed in the last two minutes (d) behavioural

**7.** Therapeutic silence after an emotional statement should usually be: (a) filled quickly (b) held for 10 15 seconds (c) ended by offering a tissue (d) followed by a question

**8.** In a family with coercive control, enactment of conflict is: (a) recommended (b) contraindicated (c) neutral (d) required

**9.** Asking "why did you shout?" is discouraged because it invites: (a) facts (b) defence or invention (c) circular information (d) emotion

**10.** A good ending includes: (a) a new diagnosis (b) a relapse plan (c) a friendship (d) a referral to another therapist

### Answer key

1 c 2 b 3 b 4 b 5 b 6 c 7 b 8 b 9 b 10 b

### Short answer

1. Write one example of each: linear, circular, reflexive and scaling question, on the same topic.
2. Give the four steps of enactment with the exact words you would use for step 1.
3. What are the three tests of a good reframe?
4. Name four reasons between-session tasks fail.
5. How would you structure a session for a family with a 7-year-old and a 15-year-old?

### Essay (choose one, 1,800 words)

1. "Technique is the servant of the alliance." Discuss with reference to your own observed sessions.
2. Analyse a transcript of your own session and identify three moments where a different choice was available. Justify each alternative with theory.
3. How should a family therapist adapt technique for a family in which the father is structurally absent?

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## Further reading


- Minuchin, S., & Fishman, H. C. (1981). Family Therapy Techniques. Harvard University Press.
- Tomm, K. (1988). Interventive interviewing: Part III. Family Process, 27(1), 1 15.
- Hepworth, M., & Larsen, J. (1993). Direct Social Work Practice. Brooks/Cole. (Micro-skills chapters)
- Butler, C., & Pilling, S. (2020). Competence Framework for Systemic Family and Couple Therapy. UCL.
- Pilling, S., & Fornells-Ambrojo, M. (2015). Supervision and Consultation. UCL Competence Frameworks.


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Next: MFT 707 Assessment and Diagnosis in Family Therapy